



Examinations Policy

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Version Control			
Previous Version	New Version	Date	Update/Notes
V2 (28/06/25)	V3	26-08-25	Reformatted and added version control table.
V3 (25-08-25)	V4.1	30-08-26	Link to JCQ updated and Link to Data Protection Act 2018 Section 51 removed as not directly relevant. Also, a new section on retention of exam scripts has been added in alignment with the TEC Data Protection Policy.

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1. Purpose and Scope

This policy ensures that Trent Education Centre (TEC) conducts examinations in a fair and consistent manner, meeting the requirements and criteria of the Joint Council for Qualifications (JCQ), the applicable Awarding Body/Organisation, and any university or TEC partner.

This policy applies to any exam and assessment submission that is required of any TEC student who comes to the campus for the purpose of sitting an exam, including outside exams and tests that TEC has created. Assessments of coursework handled under the Assessment Policy are not included in examinations.

2. Aims

- To oversee the reliability and fairness of all examinations
- To make sure that faculty, staff, and students are aware of their roles and expectations regarding exams.
- To oversee the examination process in a way that satisfies the requirements and standards of pertinent awarding bodies and partner organisations.

3. Objectives

- To give precise directions on how exams should be overseen and conducted.
- To ensure that exams are held in secure locations where they cannot be viewed by any unauthorised person before sitting the exam
- To provide that staff members in charge of exams make reasonable accommodations for students with special needs or disabilities when necessary
- To provide clear instructions on expected behaviour during examinations and the potential penalties for misconduct
- To provide pertinent information for online examinations

4. Responsibilities

The Head of Community Learning for Level 1-Level 3 examinations and the Head of Higher Education for Level 4-Level 7 examinations will appoint the Exams Officers and Invigilators.

4.1. The Exams Officer is responsible for:

- Handling the management of all examinations at TEC.
- Counselling tutors and other pertinent support staff regarding exam schedules and application procedures as established by the applicable awarding body or organisation (e.g., Pearson)
- Handling all examinations, including communication with the Awarding Body/Organisation to guarantee that all exams are conducted in compliance with deadlines and regulations.
- Creating and distributing a calendar, with schedule for all exams to staff and candidates
- Staying on campus during exam periods and providing support for online submissions.
- Coordinating with the Programme Leader, answering to the Head of Higher Education for exams at Level 4 or above and the Head of Community Learning for exams at Level 1 through to Level 3.
- Designating, training, and supervising Invigilators for every exam at the designated campus
- The Exams Officer is also in charge of making sure that all candidates show up at the correct campus and that the exam rooms are set up properly, as stated in the **checklist** below:

Environment	Adequate heating, lighting, ventilation, and noise-cancelling arrangements.
No displays	No obvious materials that could be useful to candidates displayed in the exam room.
Clock	An accurate clock visible to all candidates in the exam room.
Exam information	All pertinent exam information, including any requirements from the Awarding Organisation and the start and end times of the examination, adequately displayed for all candidates to see.
Seating arrangement	Seats arranged so that they are at least 1.25 metres (centre-to-centre) apart, all candidates face the same direction, and they cannot unintentionally see each other's work. Candidates must have their own appropriately sized desk and chair, and they must sit in a predetermined sequence.
Room map	A map of the room showing each candidate's location must be recorded.
Adjustments	Candidates who may require extra help or who may be in a different room due to a disability or special need are subject to the same criteria as above.

4.2. Invigilators are responsible for:

- Presenting themselves to the Exams Officer at the designated site.
- Obtaining and verifying exam papers and additional exam resources from the Head of Higher Education.
- Preserving the exam's integrity.
- Distributing exam papers in the exam room in line with the seating arrangement.
- Finishing the exam register.
- Recording exam details in the exam logbook, including complete reports on any unusual events or malpractice incidents.
- Gathering all exam papers and scripts in the proper sequence at the end of each exam and securely returning them to the Head of Higher Education.
- Respecting the guidelines and policies set forth by the Head of Higher Education for Invigilators.

4.3. Candidate Responsibilities

- Exam schedule checking and timely attendance at all planned exams.
- Notifying the Head of Higher Education of their desire to be removed from a specific exam.
- Acknowledging internally generated work as their own by signing a declaration and comprehending the requirements of the coursework.

5. Exam Locations

Currently, the following Study Centres are available for examinations:

Nottingham	Leicester	Birmingham
Head Office & Delivery Site Trent Education Centre Digital House 2.3, Clarendon Park Nottingham NG5 1AH	Delivery Site Trent Education Centre Humberstone House 81-83 Humberstone Gate Leicester LE1 1WB	Delivery Site Trent Education Centre Mill Wharf Mill Street Birmingham B6 4BS

6. Safe Custody of Examination Materials

Exam materials that are provided to TEC must be thoroughly inspected to make sure that:

- There are no differences between what is needed and what is received.
- There is no damage to the materials that would make them unusable.
- There is no proof of a security breach.

6.1. Examinations Security

The front desk staff at each location are responsible of ensuring that any exams that are delivered to the study centre are given to the on-site Exams Officer (EO), who has been designated by the Head of Higher Education. Until the EO picks them up and signs for them, the front desk staff is required to hang on to the delivery.

At the centre, there needs to be a designated exam storeroom with cabinets for storage. If the ground floor storeroom contains windows, it is required to install sturdy security bars, such as metal ones. The door itself must have sturdy hinges, a lock, and be extremely sturdy. Exam papers must be kept secure in the exam storeroom in a sturdy, non-portable, metal cabinet that is fireproof. The following employees are permitted entry into the Exam Storeroom:

- Head of Higher Education and Exams Officer
- Head of Community Learning
- Programme Leader

No additional stakeholder is allowed unsupervised access to the storeroom. The Head of Higher Education must be notified right away in the event of a security breach, fire, robbery, damage, or unauthorised disclosure of test contents.

Unless otherwise directed, the stored exam papers cannot be opened earlier than four hours prior to the exam's start time. The exam room is where they need to be opened. Exam papers should be securely stored when they are opened and should not be permitted to leave the premises.

7. Invigilation Arrangements

All invigilators must have a DBS, the necessary credentials, experience, and training, according to the exams officer. Remaining in the exam room and ensuring that the applicants follow all rules is the invigilator's responsibility. None of the candidates' relatives may be related to the invigilator.

Before the exam, the invigilators will receive training from the exams officer. During the examination, invigilators are not allowed to engage in any activity and are not allowed to converse with one another about anything. Candidates may only discuss information needed to correctly complete the exam with the invigilator. The following conditions must be fulfilled for invigilation:

- Up to 30 candidates must have at least one invigilator.
- Invigilators may take breaks if someone else steps in to take their place.
- The Exams Officer and other pertinent staff must be easily accessible to an invigilator working alone.
- The invigilator must be able to see each candidate clearly during the exam.
- The invigilator must be aware of these guidelines and should read the important rules to candidates prior to the exam.
- Before the exam begins, the invigilator must take registration, verify each candidate's identity, and request identification if necessary.
- The Invigilator is responsible for addressing any issues that may come up during the exam.
- Question papers and completed scripts should be turned into the Exams Officer, it will be kept in the storeroom and locked away once the exam is over.

If an unforeseen circumstance occurs during the exam, invigilators and the exam officer may need to exercise their judgement. Any judgement made by the invigilator should be based on the primary tenet that no candidate has been given an unfair advantage, and it should be noted in the exam room logbook.

To ensure that the room is ready before the applicants arrive, invigilators must be in the examination room at least thirty minutes before the exam begins. Invigilators need to be on the lookout. To avoid disturbing the students, they should occasionally get up from their seat and move around the room. They should check what is on students' desks as they go around. At the conclusion of the exam, examiners are responsible for making sure that all question-and-answer papers are gathered and given to the exams officer to be kept in the exam storeroom.

8. Examination Conduct

- Candidates are required to adhere to the guidelines provided by the Invigilator.
- At the request of the Invigilator, candidates must present identification documentation.
- Candidates should raise their hand to ask the Invigilator for anything, such as to use the lavatory.
- If a candidate needs to use the bathroom, they should be led out by another invigilator. There should be male and female invigilators on hand to lead the respective candidate to the lavatory.
- If there is any doubt regarding a candidate's identification, it should be communicated to the Exams Officer.
- Candidates have up to 15 minutes before the exam begins to enter the room.
- Candidates who come more than one hour late will still be permitted to sit the exam; however, the invigilator must note the time of arrival.
- Candidates who arrive more than sixty minutes late will not be permitted to take the test.
- Candidates are required to seek permission from the invigilator if they wish to leave before the exam ends.
- During the exam, candidates should not speak. A candidate may be disqualified if they converse with another candidate.
- During the exam, candidates are only allowed to consume water, unless there are medical reasons why they need to consume something else.
- The candidate must leave all belongings, including books, phones, and bags, in a designated area of the exam room until they have completed it and left. TEC will not accept any kind of cheating, and candidates who are found to have done so will be disqualified and their information reported to the awarding organization(s).

8.1. Academic Misconduct

TEC's Academic Misconduct Policy should be familiar to candidates, invigilators, and the Exams Officer. Any candidate who the invigilator finds to have engaged in malpractice must report the matter to the Exams Officer, who has the authority to disqualify and remove a candidate from the room, particularly if their actions are interfering with other students. A report and all supporting documentation, including witness statements, must be sent to the Head of Community Learning or Head of Higher Education for each candidate who has been declared ineligible by the exams officer. For further information, see the section on academic misconduct below and TEC's complete academic misconduct policy.

8.2. Finishing Exams

- Candidates will receive a warning five minutes before the exam's end.
- Candidates who arrive late may be granted additional time at the end to make up for lost time if they began the exam within an hour of its commencement.
- The candidates must exit the exam room once all scripts have been collected.
- The Invigilator must make sure that the candidates have completed any cover pages to the exam papers when they turn them in.
- The Invigilator must arrange all the exam papers at the end in the order listed in the attendance register and give them the attendance register, room map, and any logbook notes regarding unusual circumstances or misconduct, if applicable, to the Exams Officer.

9. Administration

The Exams Officer is responsible for ensuring:

- Proper ordering and labelling of all examination papers.
- Accurate completion of the attendance register is made.
- Exam papers are sealed in envelopes if they must be sent to examiners for marking.
- All papers are sent via recorded delivery.
- Exam papers are sent to assessors/markers no later than one day following the exam.
- If exam papers are left overnight, they are locked up in the storeroom.
- Exam details are also kept on file, along with seating arrangements, registrations, room maps, and logbooks, until the results are received.

9.1. Reasonable Adjustments for Disability & Special Considerations

TEC is committed to make sure that appropriate accommodations are made for candidates with disabilities or other support needs who wish to take exams, as mandated by the Disability Discrimination Act 2005 and the Equalities Act.

9.2. Access Arrangements

A student who discloses that they have special needs or disabilities will be directed to a support office or counsellor. The support officer or counsellor will inform the Programme Leader whether candidates need special accommodations for a disability/special need to study and take exams. Programme Leaders shall provide this information to the Exams Officer, who will make reasonable accommodations to ensure that applicants with impairments and additional support needs can sit the exam. The Exams Officer will submit completed applications for access arrangements to the Awarding Body/Organisation if necessary.

The Exams Officer is responsible for making ensuring that candidates with disabilities or special needs have reasonable access to the rooms and equipment. Examiners may provide candidates with a private room to take the test if needed; these candidates will be observed by the Exams Officer.

9.3. Examination Materials and Equipment

TEC will supply all exam-related supplies and equipment, such as paper, a computer, and a calculator, in addition to pens and pencils.

Candidates are required to leave any supplies or equipment outside the exam room or give them to the invigilator, who will keep them at the exam room front desk until the applicant finishes the test

9.4. Online Examination

TEC may offer online examinations, and, in such circumstances, each candidate must have a single Invigilator. The following regulations and policies will be in effect:

- The exam will be administered online using Microsoft Teams or Zoom.
- The Examiner will schedule a virtual meeting ten minutes prior to the start of the test.
- The student will present a passport containing their name and photo so that the Examiner can verify the identity of the candidate.
- The Examiner will provide an overview of the test, including the number of questions and time allotted.
- The Invigilator will share their screen with the Examination tasks on it.
- The Invigilator will record the Exam.
- Every test will be divided into segments, each lasting no more than sixty minutes, with a fifteen-minute break in between.
- The student will scan or take a picture of the paper at the end of each section and email the completed work to the Invigilator.
- In the event of a technical issue, the Invigilator and the Student will have a video conference over WhatsApp until the issue is resolved.
- If technical issue lasts till 15 minutes, the new date will be arranged for exam.

10. Additional guidelines for the candidate taking online assessments:

To finish the assessment, the candidate needs to have enough paper and writing supplies. A recommended option for paper would be:

- A4 letter or a comparable size format
- Feint-ruled (ideally broad) with margins.
- White, or barely coloured
- Unreflective

For maximum contrast, write on white or lightly coloured paper using just dark ink—preferably blue or black. To make it easier for examiners to grade the work, leave the left and right margins clear. Put a unique page number and, if applicable, a specific question number at the top of each page. Examiners will benefit from this when the work is scanned, photographed, and organised. Make sure the answers are the following when scanning or taking photos of them:

- Scanned in the correct order.
- Correctly oriented.
- Legible (i.e., scans are not blurry, and all fine detail can be appropriately magnified for reading)
- Complete (i.e., significant work has not been unintentionally clipped out).

In case there are any technical issues with the online platform, the candidate should make sure they have all the Invigilator's contact information, including their email address and phone number.

All TEC standards and procedures that regulate how exams are to be delivered in physical classrooms still apply, even if the exam will be administered online. Please see the sections on Examination Processes, Academic Misconduct, and Student Disciplinary Policies in this policy for more information.

11. Retention

In alignment with JISC, Sector-standard FE/HE retention periods, the Limitation Act 1980 and awarding-body and organisation requirements, TEC retains exam scripts for 6 years unless otherwise required by the awarding body or organisation. See the TEC Data Retention Policy for more information.